

Adult Grooming: A Critical Review of the Peer-Reviewed Literature

TL;DR

- The scholarly literature treats "adult grooming" as a real, theoretically coherent phenomenon — a staged process of victim selection, trust-building, isolation, desensitization, and coercive maintenance — but the empirical evidence base remains thin, fragmented across siloed sub-literatures (clergy abuse, sex trafficking, sport, romance fraud, coercive control, cultic studies), and dominated by a single conceptual model (Sinnamon, 2017) that has been formally validated in only one peer-reviewed case study (Jeglic & Winters, 2023).
- Across contexts, the same core mechanisms recur: exploitation of structural power imbalances, "predatory helpfulness" / love-bombing, intermittent reinforcement, isolation from support networks, boundary erosion ("slippery slope"), and trauma-coerced attachment — producing PTSD rates in adult survivors that, in some samples, exceed those of combat veterans.
- The single most important conceptual gap is the absence of a content-validated, adult-specific grooming model and standardized measure analogous to Winters & Jeglic's Sexual Grooming Model (SGM) for children; the most important practice gap is widespread misrecognition of adult grooming as "an affair," "a bad relationship," or "a scam victim's fault," which suppresses disclosure, reporting, and prosecution.

Key Findings

1. Definitional landscape. The dominant peer-reviewed definition of grooming remains Craven, Brown, & Gilchrist's (2006, *Journal of Sexual Aggression*, 12[3], 287–299) child-focused formulation: "a process by which a person prepares a child, significant adults and the environment for the abuse of this child" (p. 297). [Bath](#) Adult grooming has been defined most prominently by Sinnamon (2017) as "any situation in which an adult is primed to permit themselves to be abused and/or exploited for [the] sexual gratification of another" [ScienceDirect](#) [waldenu](#) (p. 462), and by Raine (2021) as situations in which "an adult is susceptible to abuse or exploitation for sexual satisfaction through emotional and psychological manipulation tactics." [Waldenu](#) There is no consensus adult-specific definition. Aletky, Sharma, Carbajal, & Eubank's (2025, *Journal of Social Work in the Global*

Community, 9, 1–17) systematic review found only five empirical studies meeting inclusion criteria for adult sexual grooming, [Waldenu](#) with just one (Jeglic & Winters, 2023) directly applying a grooming model to adults.

2. Foundational theoretical models.

- *Finkelhor (1984) Four Preconditions Model of Sexual Abuse* — the foundation on which most subsequent grooming stage-models build.
- *Craven, Brown, & Gilchrist (2006)* — three-domain framework: self-grooming, grooming of the environment/significant others, and grooming of the victim.
- *Winters & Jeglic Sexual Grooming Model (SGM)* — five empirically content-validated stages (victim selection; gaining access and isolation; trust development; desensitization to sexual content/physical contact; post-abuse maintenance) with 42 specific behaviors [Taylor & Francis Online](#) (Winters, Jeglic, & Kaylor, 2020, *Journal of Child Sexual Abuse*, 29[7], 855–875). The companion Sexual Grooming Scale–Victim Version (Winters & Jeglic, 2021, *Victims & Offenders*) operationalizes the model. Designed for children but applied speculatively to adults.
- *Sinnamon (2017) Seven-Stage Model of Adult Sexual Grooming* (in *The Psychology of Adult Sexual Grooming*, in Petherick (Ed.), *Applied Crime Analysis*, Elsevier, pp. 459–487): (1) victim selection via vulnerability cues; (2) information gathering; (3) creating a personal connection / false intimacy; (4) meeting needs and establishing credentials; (5) priming (emotional dependency, isolation, desensitization); (6) instigating sexual contact; (7) controlling the victim. [waldenu](#) This is the only stage-model designed specifically for adults but lacks empirical validation.
- *Brackenridge (2001) four-stage sport-specific grooming model* — targeting, building trust/friendship, developing isolation/control, building loyalty, and initiation of abuse/securing secrecy [Sage Journals](#) (*Spoilsports: Understanding and Preventing Sexual Exploitation in Sport*, Routledge).
- *Whitty (2013) Scammers Persuasive Techniques Model* (*British Journal of Criminology*, 53[4], 665–684) — a stage model derived from interviews with 20 romance-scam victims, explicitly characterizing the post-motivation phase as grooming prior to financial requests. [Monash University](#)
- *Basra, Kenney, Forrest-Bank, Zottarelli, & Raghavan (2023) Predatory Helpfulness framework* (*Journal of Human Trafficking*, advance online, DOI: 10.1080/23322705.2023.2259263) — a two-prong model with distinct grooming and recruitment stages for sex trafficking.
- *Lifton (1961/1989) Eight Criteria for Thought Reform* (milieu control, mystical manipulation, demand for purity, cult of confession, sacred science, loading the

language, doctrine over person, dispensing of existence) [Cultrecovery101](#) and *Singer (1995/2003, *Cults in Our Midst*, Jossey-Bass)* six conditions of thought reform — the canonical frameworks for cultic / high-control group recruitment of adults.

- *Stark (2007) Coercive Control framework (Coercive Control: How Men Entrap Women in Personal Life, Oxford University Press)* — the dominant theoretical lens for intimate-partner adult grooming, emphasizing the strategic pattern of isolation, micro-regulation, degradation, and exploitation rather than discrete violent incidents. [Tatrungtin](#)
- *Dutton & Painter (1981, *Victimology*, 6[1–4], 139–155)* Traumatic Bonding Theory — power imbalance + intermittent reinforcement [Wikipedia](#) produces paradoxical attachment, repeatedly cited as the psychological “glue” of adult grooming.

3. Adult-specific empirical research by context.

Sexual abuse of adults (general): The first empirical case-study application of the SGM to an adult victim is Jeglic & Winters (2023, *Journal of Forensic Psychology Research and Practice*, 24[4], 309–333, DOI: 10.1080/24732850.2023.2177577); the participant, “Sara,” endorsed behaviors mapping onto all five SGM stages, suggesting “considerable overlap between the behaviors and tactics outlined in the SGM and adult sexual abuse perpetrated by a known individual.” [Taylor & Francis Online](#) Winters & Jeglic’s (2022) chapter “Adults and Sexual Grooming” (in *Sexual Grooming: Integrating Research, Practice, Prevention, and Policy*, Springer, Ch. 12) is the most comprehensive synthesis to date but acknowledges that “this phenomenon has yet to be explored empirically.” [Springer](#)

Workplace / academic grooming: Bull & Page (2021, *Gender and Education*, 33[8], 1057–1072, DOI: 10.1080/09540253.2021.1884199) interviewed 16 UK university students who attempted to report staff sexual misconduct; 8 described grooming and boundary-blurring behaviors. They explicitly extend the term beyond child-protection law, defining grooming as “a pattern of [boundary-blurring] behaviours over time between people in positions of unequal power that may lead to an abuse of power,” arguing the term is needed to capture how heterosexualized normativity and student–staff power asymmetries vitiate consent. The structural prevalence backdrop is documented by the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine, *Sexual Harassment of Women: Climate, Culture, and Consequences in Academic Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine* (National Academies Press, 2018, eds. Benya, Widnall, & Johnson), which found that “50% of female faculty and staff and 20 to 50% of students” [C&EN](#) in academic STEM had experienced sexual harassment — second only to the military [Thesandersfirmpc](#) among U.S. occupational sectors.

Sex trafficking: Basra et al. (2023, *Journal of Human Trafficking*) developed Predatory Helpfulness from a pilot of 19 trafficked women; 18/19 reported the initial pimp relationship as “positive and helpful” and 17/19 identified a distinct shift from grooming to recruitment.

[Taylor & Francis Online](#) Kenney & Raghavan (2024, *Journal of Human Trafficking*, DOI: 10.1080/23322705.2024.2327950) replicated and expanded the framework with 59 international survivors: 58 of 59 (98%) matched Predatory Helpfulness tactics across grooming and recruitment stages, 50 of 59 (85%) spontaneously identified the relational shift, [Taylor & Francis Online](#) and 68% specifically endorsed love-bombing. [The Exodus Road](#) Traffickers "prevail upon those in crisis via multiple grooming tactics, and to do so quickly (i.e., move to shift the relationship into exploitation within six months)." Winters, Jeglic, & colleagues have also proposed a Sexual Grooming Model of Child Sex Trafficking (SGM-CST) [PubMed Central](#) extending SGM to trafficking contexts.

Intimate partner violence / coercive control: Stark (2007) is the foundational text. Kassing & Collins (2026, *Journal of Interpersonal Violence*, OnlineFirst, DOI: 10.1177/08862605251320998) propose "coercive control trauma" as a standalone construct based on thematic analysis of 15 Australian victim-survivors. Lesiak & Gelsthorpe (2025, *Violence Against Women*, DOI: 10.1177/10778012251379423) integrate behavioral conditioning, attachment theory, grooming theory, and coercive control, [Sage Journals](#) introducing the "two-faced soulmate" [Sage Journals](#) perpetrator profile and "weaponized attachment" as a deliberate strategy. Klein (2023, *Personal Relationships*, 30[4]) found love-bombing preceded gaslighting in the majority of an IPV survivor sample.

[Wiley Online Library](#)

Clergy / institutional grooming of adults: The seminal prevalence study is Garland & Argueta (2010, *Social Work & Christianity*, 37[1], 1–27), drawing on the 2008 General Social Survey: 3.1% of adult women who attend religious services at least monthly reported having been the object of a clergy sexual advance since age 18. [Bishop Accountability](#) [Baylor University](#) Pooler & Barros-Lane (2022, *Social Work*, 67[2], 123–133, DOI: 10.1093/sw/swac001) — a national mixed-methods survey of 159 adult Protestant women — reported that fewer than 10% received congregational support after disclosure and about half were blamed; [nih](#) [ResearchGate](#) the average duration of abuse was approximately 4 years. [Thebhhs](#) [MDPI](#) Pooler & Driesch (2025, *Pastoral Psychology*, 74, DOI: 10.1007/s11089-025-01228-0; n = 149) found that, among survivors screening positive for PTSD, 95% reported significant impairment in friendships, 90% in life satisfaction, 89% in disordered eating, and 81% in spiritual life and physical health. [Springer](#) Moncrief-Stuart & Pooler (2025, *Traumatology*, advance online, DOI: 10.1037/trm0000542) report that 39% of adult clergy sexual abuse survivors screen positive for PTSD — a higher rate than typically found among U.S. veterans [Baylor University](#) of Iraq and Afghanistan, exceeded only by incarcerated women and Military Sexual Trauma survivors. [MDPI](#)

Therapist / professional grooming: Pope's (1990, *Clinical Psychology Review*, 10[4], 477–490) "Therapist–patient sexual involvement: A review of the research" and Gabbard's body of work establish the "slippery slope" or progressive boundary-violation model (Gutheil & Gabbard, 1993, *American Journal of Psychiatry*, 150[2], 188–196). Celenza & Gabbard

(2003, *Journal of the American Psychoanalytic Association*) analyze rehabilitative trajectories of analysts who commit sexual boundary violations; Steinberg, Alpert, & Courtois (2021, *Sexual Boundary Violations in Psychotherapy: Facing Therapist Indiscretions, Transgressions, and Misconduct*, APA Books) is the recent canonical synthesis.

Sport: Brackenridge (2001) and Brackenridge & Fasting (2005, *Journal of Sexual Aggression*, 11[1], 33–52) remain foundational. Owton & Sparkes (2017, *Sport, Education and Society*, 22[6], 732–743) provide a key collaborative-autoethnographic case ("Bella's story"). Bjørnseth & Szabo (2018, *Journal of Child Sexual Abuse*) and Gaedicke et al. (2021) systematic reviews confirm grooming as the dominant pathway. Coaches were shown to use "father-figure" framing [Frontiers](#) and graduated physical contact to normalize boundary erosion.

Romance scams / financial exploitation: Whitty (2013) and Whitty & Buchanan (2016, *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking*, 19[10], 599–605) — "double hit" of financial loss and [Semantic Scholar](#) relational betrayal. Coluccia et al. (2020, *Frontiers in Psychiatry*, 11, 1108) provide a scoping review; Buil-Gil & Zeng (2022) and Cross et al. (2018) document grooming durations of 6–8 months prior to first financial request.

[ResearchGate](#)

Cults / high-control groups: Lifton (1961/1989, *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism*, UNC Press) and Singer (1995/2003, *Cults in Our Midst*, Jossey-Bass) are the canonical empirical-clinical works. Ofshe & Singer (1986, *Cultic Studies Journal*) and Singer (1996, *Transactional Analysis Journal*) develop the coercive-persuasion / thought-reform framework. ICSA-affiliated researchers have extended this work but most cult-recovery literature remains clinical/observational rather than experimentally controlled.

4. Psychological mechanisms.

- *Traumatic bonding* (Dutton & Painter, 1981) — emotional attachment forged by intermittent reinforcement in a power-imbalanced relationship.
- *Trauma-coerced bonding* (Doychak & Raghavan, 2018, *Dignity*, 3[1]) — extension specifically for sex-trafficking contexts adding social isolation and perceived inescapability.
- *Coercive control* (Stark, 2007) — the architecture of micro-regulation.
- *Intermittent reinforcement / behavioral addiction analogues* — recent integrative work (Lesiak & Gelsthorpe, 2025) parallels grooming dynamics to behavioral addiction.
- *Cognitive distortions / neutralization techniques* — Spraitz & Bowen (2016, *Sexual Abuse*, 28[5], 453–475) document neutralizations in clergy offender files; perpetrators reframe abuse as "an affair," "ministry," or "consensual."

- *Vulnerability factors* — recurrent across literatures: prior trauma/CSA, recent loss or transition, social isolation, dependence on perpetrator for income/immigration status/spiritual guidance, low self-esteem, mental illness, substance use, and structural marginalization. Many studies note groomers actively *manufacture* vulnerability rather than passively select for it.

5. Psychological sequelae documented in adult grooming victims.

- PTSD and complex PTSD: Moncrief-Stuart & Pooler (2025) document 39% PTSD rates among adult clergy sexual abuse survivors. Whitty & Buchanan (2016) found clinical depression and significant psychological [Semantic Scholar](#) distress in romance scam victims comparable to bereavement.
- Self-blame, shame, humiliation: Universal across clergy, IPV, romance-scam, and trafficking samples; underreporting is consistently attributed to these affective sequelae.
- Loss of faith / spiritual injury in religious contexts.
- Suicidal ideation: documented in adult CSA-survivor samples and adult clergy sexual abuse samples.
- Institutional betrayal trauma (Smith & Freyd, 2014, *American Psychologist*, 69[6], 575–587) — secondary harm from organizational responses; specifically applied to adult clergy abuse by Moncrief-Stuart & Pooler (2025).
- Posttraumatic growth: Calhoun & Tedeschi's (2004) framework is applied to IPV recovery, with growth domains including new possibilities, personal strength, and spiritual change. [ResearchGate](#)

6. Critiques, gaps, and limitations.

- Lanning (2018, *Journal of Interpersonal Violence*, 33[1], 5–16) cautions that "grooming" lacks "one official, legal, mental health, or even lay definition"; [Wikipedia](#) he prefers retaining both "grooming" and "seduction" to maintain conceptual precision.
- Bennett & O'Donohue (2014, *Journal of Child Sexual Abuse*, 23[8], 957–976) identified 12 different grooming definitions in the literature.
- Wood & Wheatcroft (2020, *SAGE Open*, 10[1]) found young adults frequently do not know what "grooming" means, and propose "sexual manipulation" as a clearer term.
- The term has been politicized (e.g., U.S. legislative debates around 2022–2023) in ways academics argue dilute its analytical utility.
- For *adults* specifically: Aletky et al. (2025) found only five empirical studies in their

systematic review; Winters & Jeglic (2022) concede the phenomenon “has yet to be explored empirically” beyond a case study. There is no validated adult equivalent of the Sexual Grooming Scale.

- Sinnamon’s seven-stage adult model, while widely cited in practice settings, is criticized in the peer-reviewed literature for lacking empirical validation and for assuming children and adults share underlying mechanisms despite differences in agency, cognitive maturity, and legal consent. [waldenu](#)
- Most adult-grooming literature is qualitative, retrospective, single-context, and small-sample; convenience samples drawn from survivor networks or online panels predominate.
- Cross-cultural generalizability is poor — most studies are from the U.S., U.K., Australia, and continental Europe.
- The line between criminal grooming and ordinary courtship/persuasion remains contested, particularly in adult contexts where legal capacity to consent is intact.

Details

The clearest synthesis of where the field stands is in the Winters & Jeglic (2022) Springer chapter and the Aletky et al. (2025) systematic review. Both agree that (a) adult sexual grooming is a real, recognizable process; (b) it shares core architecture with child grooming (selection, access, trust, isolation, desensitization, maintenance); but (c) it differs in critical respects — adults are presumed to have legal capacity to consent, so groomers must work harder to manufacture epistemic confusion, isolate the victim from corroborating perspectives, and exploit *structural* power (clerical authority, professional licensure, employer relationship, immigration status, financial dependence, in-group ideology). This is why adult grooming clusters so heavily in institutional contexts — clergy, therapy, sport coaching, academic supervision, military, and cult/high-control group settings.

Sinnamon’s (2017) seven-stage model is the only model designed specifically for adults but remains theoretically derived rather than empirically validated. Jeglic & Winters’ (2023) case study of “Sara” is the first peer-reviewed empirical application of a grooming model (the SGM) to an adult abuse case. The participant endorsed behaviors across all five SGM stages, including the perpetrator selecting a vulnerable target (severe trauma history, mental health difficulties, contentious family relationships), [Waldenu](#) gaining access through a professional role, building trust, desensitizing the victim to sexual content, and using post-abuse maintenance tactics.

In sex trafficking, the Predatory Helpfulness framework (Basra et al., 2023; Kenney & Raghavan, 2024) represents the most empirically grounded adult-specific grooming model.

Its key contribution is conceptualizing a discrete *relational shift* from a grooming stage (love-bombing, housing/financial help, drugs, emotional support, addressing a crisis) to a recruitment stage in which coercive control activates the victim into commercial sexual exploitation — a shift that 85% of Kenney & Raghavan's 59 survivors spontaneously named.

[Taylor & Francis Online](#) Crucially, the framework operationalizes "force, fraud, or coercion"

[ResearchGate](#) under U.S. federal trafficking law in survivor-recognizable language.

In intimate partner violence, Stark's (2007) coercive control framework has effectively absorbed and superseded older "cycle of violence" models (Walker, 1979) as the dominant theoretical lens. Recent extensions emphasize that physical captivity or financial dependence are not necessary for trauma bonding; bonds can be manufactured through alternating affection and cruelty (the "two-faced soulmate" profile; Lesiak & Gelsthorpe, 2025). Coercive control has now been criminalized in England and Wales (Serious Crime Act 2015), Scotland, Ireland, several Australian states, and a growing number of U.S. jurisdictions — a legal acknowledgment of grooming-like patterned behavior.

In clergy contexts, the Baylor research program led by Diana Garland, David Pooler, and colleagues has produced the strongest empirical evidence base for any adult-grooming context. Garland & Chaves' (2009) GSS estimate of 3.1% lifetime prevalence among adult women who attend services at least monthly, combined with Pooler & Barros-Lane's (2022) n=159 survey documenting an average abuse duration of 4 years and Moncrief-Stuart & Pooler's (2025) 39% PTSD prevalence, establishes adult clergy sexual abuse as a population-significant public-health and institutional problem. The legal landscape has evolved rapidly: as of May 2026, at least 15 U.S. states plus the District of Columbia explicitly criminalize adult clergy sexual abuse — the 13 states (Arkansas, Connecticut, Delaware, Iowa, Maine, Minnesota, New Mexico, North Dakota, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Wisconsin) [Bishop Accountability](#) plus D.C. documented by [BishopAccountability.org](#) as of January 2024, joined by Massachusetts (law effective November 6, 2024) [Clergysexualmisconduct](#) and Georgia (SB 542, signed by Governor Brian Kemp on May 11, [UCA News](#) 2026). [Bishop Accountability](#) Per *The Roys Report* / Religion Unplugged (May 12, 2026), "the legislation places Georgia among a growing number of states adopting laws specifically addressing clergy sexual abuse" [Bishop Accountability](#) — a legal trend that survivor-advocates argue mirrors the slow academic recognition of the phenomenon.

In therapy contexts, the literature on sexual boundary violations (Pope, 1990; Gutheil & Gabbard, 1993; Celenza, 2007; Steinberg, Alpert, & Courtois, 2021) treats grooming as the "slippery slope" of progressive boundary erosion. The benchmark national prevalence figures come from Gartrell, Herman, Olarte, Feldstein, & Localio (1986, *American Journal of Psychiatry*, 143[9], 1126–1131), who found that "7.1% (N=1,057) of the male and 3.1% (N=257) of the female respondents acknowledged sexual contact with their own patients" in a nationwide survey of U.S. psychiatrists; pooled cross-profession data (psychologists,

psychiatrists, social workers) reported in Pope (1990, *Clinical Psychology Review*) and Pope, Sonne, & Holroyd (1993) yields approximately 9.4% of male and 2.5% of female therapists.

[KsPope](#) The “sitting duck syndrome” (Kluft, 1989) describes how prior abuse survivors are at elevated risk of retraumatization in therapy [Psychiatry Online](#) — a key mechanism by which adult grooming compounds across the life course.

In sport, Brackenridge’s (2001) work — based on interviews with elite athletes — established grooming as the modal pathway for coach-perpetrated abuse. The 2003–2023 scoping review by Gaedicke et al. (2021) and the Tuakli-Wosornu et al. (2024) systematic review in *Sport, Education and Society* confirm that coach grooming follows a generalized model: targeting, building trust/friendship via “father-figure” framing, developing isolation/control (often via training camps, travel, one-on-one sessions), building loyalty, and initiating abuse.

In romance scams, Whitty’s (2013) Scammers Persuasive Techniques Model is the foundational empirical model. The Coluccia et al. (2020) scoping review identifies relationship-building over 6–8 months prior to financial requests, [ResearchGate](#) with female gender, middle age, higher impulsivity, lower social support, and certain attachment styles as risk factors. Buchanan & Whitty (2014) document a “double hit” of financial and emotional trauma.

In cult / high-control group contexts, the Lifton (1961) and Singer (1995/2003) frameworks remain dominant. Empirical studies are largely retrospective and qualitative (Langone, 1993; Hassan, 2015), with chronic underdevelopment of controlled empirical research — partly due to ethical constraints and difficulty accessing active members.

Recommendations

For researchers:

1. **Develop and content-validate an adult-specific Sexual Grooming Model and a measurement instrument** analogous to the SGM/SGS-V, drawing on the Predatory Helpfulness framework, Sinnamon’s seven stages, and the coercive-control literature. This is the single highest-leverage gap.
2. **Run prevalence studies** using nationally representative samples (the 2008 GSS clergy module is the model template) for adult grooming in workplace, therapy, sport, and online dating contexts.
3. **Move beyond case studies and convenience samples** toward prospective, multi-context, mixed-methods designs.
4. **Integrate cross-context** — most current siloing (trafficking research vs. clergy research vs. IPV research) duplicates effort; a shared taxonomy would accelerate progress.

For clinicians:

1. Screen routinely for adult-grooming markers in patients presenting with PTSD, depression, suicidality, or relational trauma — especially after clergy, therapist, supervisor, or coach involvement, or after a romance that began with “love-bombing.”
2. Use the SGS-V structure adaptively for adult patients; document specific stage-relevant behaviors.
3. Be alert to institutional betrayal trauma as a layered injury beyond the index abuse.

For institutions (faith communities, universities, sport bodies, therapy training programs):

1. Adopt zero-tolerance policies that explicitly define sexual contact in fiduciary relationships as abuse regardless of “consent,” following the model already in place for therapist–patient relationships in most U.S. licensing boards.
2. Train all members on grooming red flags (excessive attention, special treatment, secrecy, gradual boundary erosion, isolation from peers).
3. Establish independent reporting channels and trauma-informed response protocols.

For policymakers:

1. Criminalize adult clergy sexual abuse and other fiduciary-relationship sexual contact in the 35 U.S. states that have not yet done so (15 states plus D.C. have such statutes as of May 2026, following Georgia’s SB 542 in May 2026 [Bishop Accountability](#) and Massachusetts’s law in November 2024).
2. Extend coercive control statutes (now law in England/Wales, Scotland, Ireland, and a growing number of jurisdictions) to U.S. states.
3. Fund research infrastructure for adult-grooming studies through NIJ, NIH, and equivalent international bodies.

Thresholds that would change these recommendations: Publication of (a) a content-validated adult SGM with population-level prevalence data, (b) randomized prevention-intervention trials in institutional settings, or (c) revised DSM/ICD recognition of coercive-control-related trauma syndromes would each shift recommendations from “develop the evidence base” toward “scale validated interventions.”

Caveats

- The peer-reviewed empirical base on adult grooming *as such* is extremely thin: Aletky et al.’s (2025) systematic review yielded only five eligible empirical studies, [Waldenu](#) and

only one (Jeglic & Winters, 2023) directly applies a grooming model to adult sexual abuse.

- Most evidence is qualitative, retrospective, single-context, and based on convenience samples (online panels, survivor networks, support group recruitment).
- Cross-cultural research is sparse; nearly all empirical work is from Anglophone or European contexts.
- The term “grooming” has been politicized in non-academic discourse, with consequences for both research funding and public understanding; some scholars (e.g., Wood & Wheatcroft, 2020) advocate alternative terminology.
- Sinnamon’s (2017) widely cited seven-stage adult model lacks independent empirical validation; readers should treat it as a useful heuristic rather than an established framework.
- Romance-scam prevalence estimates (“63% of social media users report having been a victim at least once”) [ScienceDirect](#) in some scoping reviews appear implausibly high and likely reflect broad definitions; treat single-source prevalence figures with caution.
- The line between aggressive courtship/seduction and criminal grooming in adult contexts remains genuinely contested; academic conceptualization should not collapse this distinction in ways that pathologize ordinary persuasion or romance.
- Several key findings (e.g., the 39% PTSD figure in adult clergy sexual abuse from Moncrief-Stuart & Pooler, 2025) come from very recent (2025) advance-online publications and have not yet been independently replicated.
- Therapist-patient sexual contact prevalence figures (Gartrell et al., 1986; Pope, 1990) are based on anonymous self-report and likely underestimate the true rate; the data are also approaching 40 years old and may not reflect current professional norms or training environments.